



The Morning Brief

MAY 15, 2026

Records, Few Details

S&P clears 7,500 for the first time on the H200 chip approval as NVDA prints a record, but the Trump-Xi summit closed with claims of deals rather than substance and Beijing reportedly halted deliveries; Hormuz re-escalated, Brent extended weekly gains, and Friday futures point modestly lower.

SPY	NVDA	QCOM	HOOD	FEAR & GREED
\$748.17 ↑0.79%	\$235.74 ↑4.39%	\$200.08 ↓6.14%	\$80.70 ↑5.15%	43 · Fear

SECTION 01

Markets

S&P CLEARS 7,500 FOR THE FIRST TIME AS THE H200 APPROVAL DRIVES A CONCENTRATED AI PRINT — BUT THE SUBSTANCE BEHIND THE MOVE IS THINNER THAN THE TAPE IMPLIES

Thursday delivered the first close above 7,500 for the S&P 500 per CNBC and Yahoo Finance coverage of the session, with SPY closing at \$748.17 (+0.79%) per the data drop. The Dow reclaimed 50,000 (+0.74% to \$500.80) and the Nasdaq added 0.71% to \$719.79, all three benchmarks at record closes. The catalyst was Reuters' report that the US Commerce Department had cleared sales of Nvidia's H200 AI chips to roughly 10 Chinese firms including Alibaba, Tencent, ByteDance, JD.com, Lenovo, and Foxconn, with per-customer caps of approximately 75,000 chips. NVDA closed at a record \$235.74 (+4.39%), market cap moved to approximately \$5.7 trillion per Yahoo coverage; TSM gained 4.48% to \$417.72 on the read-through to AI-grade fab utilization. UVXY fell 3.49%, the bid for protection eased, and breadth modestly broadened as eight of eleven sectors closed positive — XLK led at +1.50% with XLE +0.76% and XLF +0.59% supporting. However, Friday's setup is more mixed: Asian markets faded the rally per CNBC's Asia wrap (Nikkei -1.1%, Hang Seng -0.89%), US futures softened (Dow -0.26%, S&P -0.37%, Nasdaq 100 -0.6% per Yahoo and CNBC pre-market coverage), and Benzinga and Reuters reported that Beijing has separately instructed Chinese firms to hold off on H200 purchases pending guidance — no actual shipments have been confirmed.

THE CHIP COMPLEX SPLIT CLEANLY — NVDA, TSM, MRVL HIGHER ON H200; QCOM CONTINUES ITS REVERSAL FROM MONDAY'S RECORD

The semiconductor sleeve traded the H200 thesis with sharp dispersion. The chips most directly levered to the Chinese AI build-out advanced: NVDA \$235.74 (+4.39%), TSM \$417.72 (+4.48%), MRVL \$182.58 (+2.60%), AMD \$449.70 (+0.94%), and LRCX \$299.15 (+1.26%). The names with less direct exposure or with separate stories sold off: QCOM declined 6.14% to \$200.08, extending the unwind from

Monday's \$237.53 record — cumulative drawdown across the four sessions since the record now approximates 16%; NXPI -1.42% to \$294.17, CRDO -2.55% to \$184.54, and ADI -1.30% to \$426.79. The pattern is consistent with positioning rotating into the names cleanest to the China-chip thaw narrative and away from the broader semi cohort that had previously absorbed flows on the earnings reset. CRDO's give-back continues to look more like profit-taking than thesis impairment, with the company's fiscal year-end print

scheduled per its Finnhub release. NVDA prints next Wednesday, May 20 — the single largest catalyst of the next week for the entire sleeve.

CRYPTO AND RETAIL-TRADING NAMES SURGE AS RISK SENTIMENT RE-ENGAGES — HOOD +5.15%, COIN +5.06%, MARA +4.24%, IBIT +2.33%

The Thursday risk-on tape extended cleanly into the digital sleeve. Per Yahoo and Benzinga session coverage, Coinbase and Robinhood led after a US crypto regulatory bill (CLARITY) advanced in Congress, and Bitcoin held above the recent trading range with IBIT closing at \$46.17 (+2.33%) and ETHA at \$17.36 (+2.00%). HOOD ended at \$80.70 (+5.15%) and COIN at \$212.01 (+5.06%) — both within IOWN's growth sleeve; MARA gained 4.24% to \$13.29 and HUT added 0.97% to \$109.37. Fear & Greed recovered to 43 (Fear) from Wednesday's 34 reading; the divergence between record indices and a sub-50 sentiment reading remains a feature of this tape rather than a regime change. CAT gained 1.99% on the Dow 50,000 milestone narrative per Yahoo. The

dividend sleeve was mixed: ABT +1.28%, CL +1.10%, SYK +1.13%, NEE +0.88% on the constructive side; GPC -1.70%, DGX -1.52%, STLD -1.01% on the other.

SPY · DOW · NASDAQ	\$748.17 ↑0.79% · \$500.80 ↑0.74% · \$719.79 ↑0.71% · All records
S&P 500 INDEX	~7,501 · First close above 7,500 per CNBC/Yahoo
NVDA · TSM · MRVL	\$235.74 ↑4.39% record · \$417.72 ↑4.48% · \$182.58 ↑2.60%
QCOM	\$200.08 ↓6.14% · ~16% off Mon's \$237.53 record
DIGITAL SLEEVE	HOOD ↑5.15% · COIN ↑5.06% · MARA ↑4.24% · IBIT ↑2.33%
UVXY (VIX PROXY)	\$35.43 · ↓3.49% · Protection bid eased
FEAR & GREED	43 · Fear (from 34 Wed)
FRIDAY FUTURES	Dow ↓0.26% · S&P ↓0.37% · Nasdaq ↓0.6%
CARSON'S ACTIVE LEVEL	SPY \$645.80 support · Untested (intraday low \$743.56)

The tape priced the H200 approval as if the shipments were a closed matter; the post-close reporting suggests they are not. The semiconductor sleeve captured the move, but the path from US licensing to actual Chinese AI-cloud spend is the catalyst that has yet to print. Research Reveals Opportunities.

Geopolitics

THE BEIJING SUMMIT CLOSES WITH HEADLINE COMMITMENTS BUT LIMITED SUBSTANCE — BOEING, SOYBEANS, OIL, AND AN IRAN-NO-NUKES ALIGNMENT

Per CNBC, Fox News, NBC News, and Al Jazeera coverage of the closing remarks at Zhongnanhai, President Trump and President Xi concluded their two-day Beijing meeting with claims of progress but few formally documented agreements. Trump told Fox News that China had agreed to order 200 Boeing aircraft; USTR Jamieson Greer said the US expects at least \$10 billion in annual US agricultural purchases over three years on top of existing soybean commitments per Reuters. Trump separately said Xi pledged China would not supply Iran with military equipment and that the two leaders aligned on the proposition that Iran should not have nuclear weapons per Reuters. Xi reportedly expressed interest in increased Chinese purchases of US oil per CNBC. The White House readout per CNN coverage indicated discussion of trade, the Iran war, and the Strait of Hormuz; Xi separately warned Trump that mishandling Taiwan could risk escalating to direct conflict per France 24 and NBC coverage of the meeting. Foreign Policy characterized the summit as producing few clear wins; Al Jazeera framed expectations as having been low going into Friday. For the IOWN framework, the read is that the H200 export approval was the most concrete deliverable of the trip, but Beijing's reported guidance to Chinese firms to hold off on chip purchases per Benzinga and Reuters tempers the near-term P&L translation.

HORMUZ RE-ESCALATES AS THE SUMMIT CLOSED — TANKER SEIZED OFF UAE, INDIAN CARGO SHIP SUNK OFF OMAN, BRENT ON TRACK FOR ~+5% ON THE WEEK

Despite the Trump-Xi alignment that the Strait must remain open, the physical environment deteriorated. Per Washington Times, Euronews, NBC News, and NPR reporting on Thursday and Friday, a tanker was seized approximately 38 nautical miles north of Fujairah, UAE, by unauthorized personnel and was tracked heading toward Iranian waters; the UK Maritime Trade Operations is investigating. Separately, the Indian-flagged cargo ship Haji Ali sank off the coast of Oman after an attack ignited a fire onboard; all 12 crew were rescued per Oman coast guard reporting. Per Reuters via OilPrice.com, Brent crude was trading above \$106 on Friday and was extending its weekly gain as diplomatic efforts continued to stall and the Strait remained effectively under selective Iranian passage controls. Within the IOWN energy sleeve, the Thursday session showed selective response: CVX +0.34%, OKE +2.52% to \$91.03, CNX +2.80% to \$36.40,

and VLO +0.27%; XLE added 0.76% on the day. The structural read is that the Hormuz disruption premium remains embedded in crude even as the diplomatic framework for resolution remains nominal rather than operational.

BEIJING SUMMIT CLOSE	Claims of 200 Boeing · \$10B/yr US ag · Xi interested in US oil · Iran no-nukes alignment per Reuters
H200 STATUS	Beijing reportedly guiding firms to hold off purchases per Benzinga/Reuters · No shipments confirmed
HORMUZ	Tanker seized off UAE · Indian cargo ship sunk off Oman per Washington Times/NBC
BRENT CRUDE	~\$106 Fri AM · Extending weekly gain per Reuters/OilPrice
ASIA FRI CLOSE	Nikkei ↓1.1% · Hang Seng ↓0.89% per CNBC
TAIWAN WARNING	Xi cautioned mishandling could risk direct conflict per France 24

On Our Radar

1. Empire State Manufacturing and Industrial Production land midday today — the soft-data print is the first read after Wednesday's hot CPI and yesterday's Schmid speech. Per the data drop's economic calendar and the Empire State release calendar, today's 7:30 AM CT release is expected at 7.5 vs. April's 11; Industrial Production at 8:15 AM CT is expected at +0.3% MoM (Prior -0.5%) with Capacity Utilization at 75.8%. Per Investing.com and FXStreet coverage of Kansas City Fed President Jeff Schmid's remarks yesterday, he characterized continued inflation as the most pressing risk to the US economy. A soft Empire print combined with an in-line Industrial Production rebound would tend to support the framework that growth is slowing while inflation remains sticky — the regime IOWN's physical-AI and dividend spine was built for. *Avoid Erosion.*

2. NVDA prints Wednesday May 20 — the largest single-name catalyst for the semiconductor sleeve and arguably for the broader tape. NVDA closed at a record \$235.74 (+4.39%) yesterday with market cap near \$5.7 trillion per Yahoo Finance. The print arrives with the H200 approval freshly in the price but with no actual Chinese shipments confirmed — positioning is now meaningfully long the chip-thaw thesis. Guidance commentary on China demand, Blackwell ramp, and data-center capex visibility will set the tone for the entire AI infrastructure complex (MRVL, TSM, CRDO, AMD). The May 11 brief noted Wells Fargo and Susquehanna had been raising targets ahead of the print; the bar is now higher than it was a week ago. *Think Like an Owner.*

3. QCOM has now retraced approximately 16% from Monday's \$237.53 record close — the rate-sensitive cohort of the chip complex is signaling that the AI-narrative tide does not lift every boat equally. QCOM closed at \$200.08 (-6.14%) yesterday after -11.46% Tuesday, +1.36% Wednesday, and -6.14% Thursday. The pattern is consistent with positioning unwinding from a name that had run on Monday's post-earnings move ahead of the broader chip cohort. A Yahoo write-up framing "Is It Too Late To Consider Qualcomm After A 50% Monthly Surge?" is consistent with the read of profit-taking rather than thesis impairment. The dispersion is a useful reminder that the semiconductor sleeve is not monolithic — the names cleanest to AI-data-center demand (NVDA, TSM, MRVL) decoupled from the broader complex on the H200 catalyst. **The physical world matters.**

4. The crypto bill advance and the digital sleeve rally suggest the regulatory backdrop is constructively shifting — HOOD +5.15%, COIN +5.06%, IBIT +2.33%, ETHA +2.00%. Per Yahoo coverage of Thursday's session, the US CLARITY crypto bill advanced in Congress, and Charles Schwab rolled out spot Bitcoin and Ethereum trading per Benzinga. IBIT and ETHA — IOWN's digital-asset ETF allocation — participated cleanly. The structural read is that the regulated rails for retail and institutional crypto access continue to broaden, which historically tends to support the platform names (COIN, HOOD) regardless of near-term Bitcoin price action. *Research Reveals Opportunities.*

5. Carson's active support at SPY \$645.80 remains untested with the index roughly 13.7% above — intraday Thursday low was \$743.56. The retracement target framework set on April 13 remains intact and unhit. With SPY at \$748.17, the level sits as a meaningful downside reference if the H200-driven advance fails to convert to confirmed Chinese chip deliveries or if the Hormuz situation continues to compress crude availability. The technical structure of the index relative to its moving averages remains constructive, but the divergence between record prices and a Fear-territory sentiment reading (43) is a feature worth noting. *Avoid Erosion.*

6. Baker Hughes rig count posts this afternoon at 12:00 PM CT — the upstream activity read against Brent's continued weekly gain is informative for the energy sleeve. Per the data drop, the prior week's oil rig count was 410 and total rigs 548. A rebuild in upstream activity would tend to support the case that the energy sector multiple has room to expand even with crude moderating, while a flat or declining count would reinforce the structural case for tighter inventories as Hormuz disruption persists. IOWN's energy sleeve (CVX, VLO, OKE, CTRA, CNX) added selectively on Thursday with OKE +2.52% and CNX +2.80% leading the cohort. **Simplicity Over Complexity.**